

Return to Search

Original Page: 255

Culture (OWC): Amhara (MP05)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1958-1961

Coverage Date: 1270-1961

Place Coverage: Ethiopia

Section Title(S): Self And Others

It is true that the forms of respect toward superiors are often repeated mechanically and sometimes serve to cover up a distinctly hostile disposition toward certain superiors. They nevertheless do respect to some extent a genuine solidaristic sentiment—perhaps the most profound and influential social sentiment in the Amhara social system. It rests in the last analysis on the fact that the Amhara family develops a pronounced sense of filial devotion as well as habits of filial obedience. Amhara society can dispense with horizontal solidarities and communal attachments because it is held together, sufficiently for traditional purposes, at least, by an infinite network of “father-son” relationships.

- 121
Theoretical Orientation
- 181
Ethos
- 554
Status, Role, And Prestige
- 571
Social Relationships And Groups
- 576
Etiquette
- 593
Family Relationships

The egoistic element in the hierarchical pattern is further modified by a sort of joking relationship that sometimes develops between inferiors and superiors. The harsh interrogation of inferiors at times shades into a sort of wry banter; sons or servants may be called “thief” or “scoundrel” in an undertone of unmistakable affection. At times, moreover, the direction of the jesting may be reversed. Amhara servants are noted for playing practical jokes on their masters, which the latter usually appreciate when the jests are clever.²²⁷ Here again, wax and gold is the perfect medium—for expressing aggression against a superior while at the same time appearing to maintain the respect relationship. The following couplet, attributed to Naggadr[unknown]as Tassama Eshate, aptly illustrates this genre:

- 113
Bibliographies In Sources
- 121
Theoretical Orientation
- 181
Ethos
- 522
Humor

09/02/2026, 13:11	Wax & Gold - eHRAF World Cultures	571 Social Relationships And Groups
<i>Ennanta maku[unknown]annentotch ba-mîn wat balatchu?</i> <i>Eññam ba-shurw[unknown]atchen enn[unknown]antam bass[unknown]atchu</i> .	121 Theoretical Orientation 181 Ethos 522 Humor 539 Literary Texts 571 Social Relationships And Groups	
What sauce, my lords, was on your plate? We had but peas; 'twas fish you ate. ²²⁸	113 Bibliographies In Sources 121 Theoretical Orientation 181 Ethos 522 Humor 571 Social Relationships And Groups	
Here the poet appears to be complimenting the nobles on their more elegant cuisine at a banquet; but there is a pun on the word <i>bass[unknown]atchu</i>, literally "with your fish," for it may also be taken to mean "you took more than your share."	121 Theoretical Orientation 181 Ethos 522 Humor 571 Social Relationships And Groups	
Within the hierarchical pattern, finally, one finds expressed a certain amount of generosity which, as we have suggested, is relatively uncommon in	121	

relations among peers. This appears in connection with the *begging* and *almsgiving* which occur in many sectors of Amhara society. For church students beyond the elementary level, begging is the primary means of livelihood. Youths who have left home to study *zema* or *qene* with a master wander about today, as in former times, carrying small baskets and pleading: "For the sake of Mary! For the sake of God!" in order to get their daily morsels. The activity is so organized that when a large number of students ■256 live near the same master, they divide up the neighboring countryside to avoid duplication in their begging.

Theoretical
Orientation

181
Ethos

571
Social Relationships
And Groups

735
Poverty

793
Priesthood

. Cf. J. I. Eadie, *An Amharic Reader* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1924), pp. 39-46.

. Mahtama-Selassie Walda-Masqal, *Amar[unknown]jiñña Qene* (Addis Ababa, 1948 E.C.), p. 53.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)